2.1.1.1 Oral Cavity

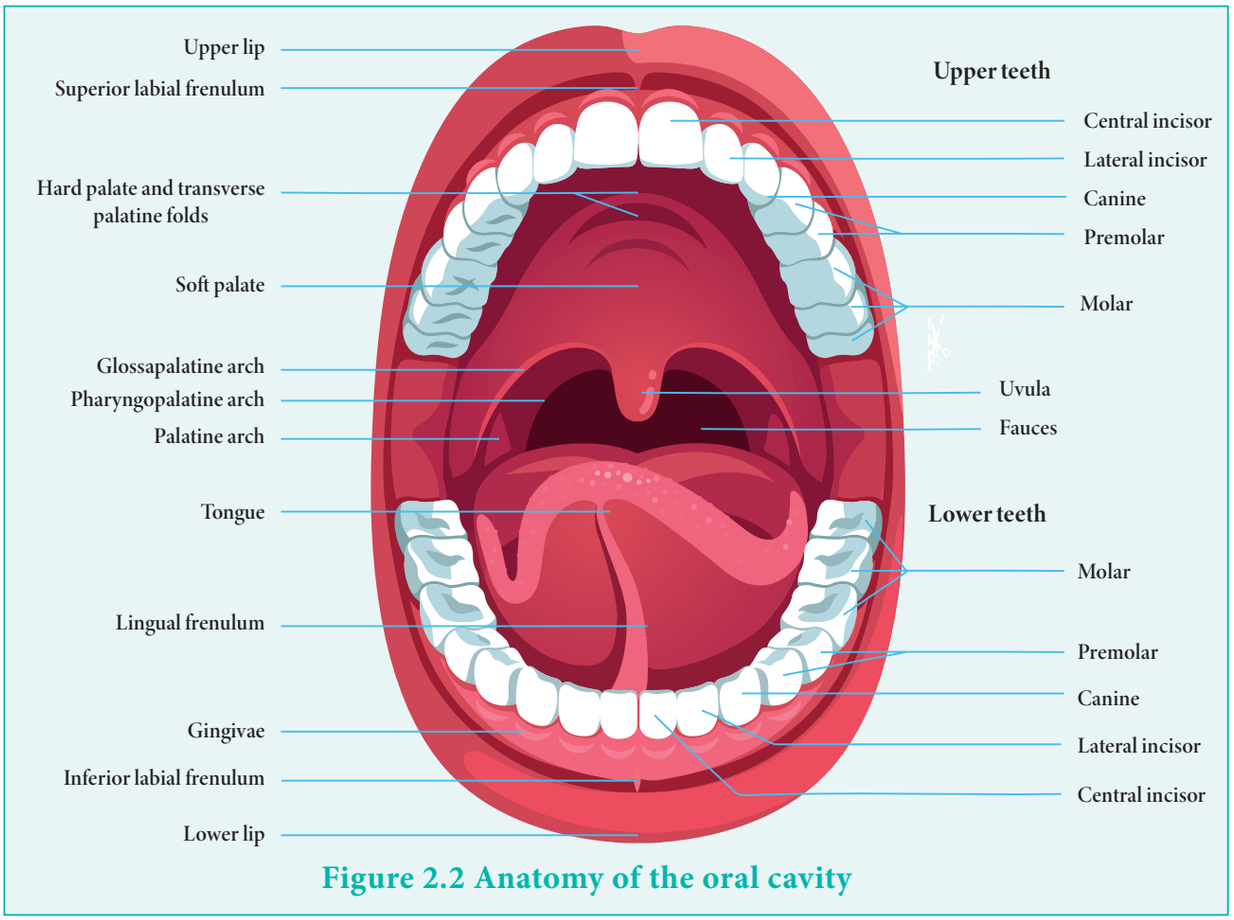


Figure 2.2 Anatomy of the oral cavity

The mouth or the oral or buccal cavity is made up of cheeks, hard and soft palates and the tongue along with the teeth embedded in the upper and lower jaws (Figure 2.2). The cheeks form the lateral walls of the oral cavity. The palate is the septum or the wall which separates the oral from the nasal cavity. The hard palate in the front is bony in structure, while the soft palate at the back is muscular in nature and separates the oropharynx from the nasopharynx. The soft palate accommodates a hanging muscular organ called uvula, meaning little grape. The tongue is a muscular organ attached by the frenulum to the floor of the buccal cavity and free in the front. It is involved in mastication of food, swallowing and also bears the taste buds. The tongue and uvula are responsible for the swallowing action. There are four types of teeth – incisors for cutting, canine for holding and tearing, premolars and molars for grinding the food. Human teeth are thecodont (embedded in socket of jaw bones), diphyodont (temporary and permanent sets of teeth) and heterodont in nature. The dental formula for each half of the upper and lower jaw of an adult is 2123/2123.

2.1.1.2 Pharynx

The pharynx is a funnel shaped structure that connects the oral and nasal cavity to oesophagus and trachea. The function of pharynx is to help in swallowing the bolus (masticated food). The whole of the pharyngeal stage of swallowing usually occurs within

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